

GENTIANALES

The order name celebrates the gentians of mountains and gardens, but the Gentianaceae family has only around 1,600 members. The madder family (Rubiaceae) is the largest in the order, with over 13,000 species, including tropical shrubs such as coffee. The oleander family (Apocynaceae), strychnine family (Loganiaceae), and jessamine family (Gelsemiaceae) complete the order.



MADAGASCAR PERIWINKLE
Catharanthus roseus
F: Apocynaceae

The leaves of this garden ornamental, endangered in its native Madagascar, contain tiny amounts of alkaloids used to treat childhood leukaemias. This use has saved it from extinction.



FIVE-PETALLED FLOWER

COMMON FRANGIPANI
Plumeria rubra
F: Apocynaceae

Native from Mexico to Venezuela, the flowers of this ornamental tree are fragrant at night and attract sphinx moths for pollination.



OLEANDER
Nerium oleander
F: Apocynaceae

All parts of this evergreen shrub are poisonous. It grows by streams from the Mediterranean to China, producing clusters of fragrant pink flowers.



BUTTERFLY WEED
Asclepias tuberosa
F: Apocynaceae

Native Americans chewed the roots of this showy perennial as a cure for pleurisy. It grows in fields and on roadsides in N. America.



BEAD PLANT
Nertera granadensis
F: Rubiaceae

Named for its small, bead-like fruits, this perennial with tiny, green flowers is native to Australia, New Zealand, Pacific islands, and S. America.



GREATER PERIWINKLE
Vinca major
F: Apocynaceae

Long, rooting stems of this evergreen perennial creep across woodland floors in S. and C. Europe and N. Africa.



CLEAVERS

Galium aparine
F: Rubiaceae

Prickles on the stem and leaf margins attach to animal fur, dispersing parts of this agricultural weed of Europe and Asia.

glossy, evergreen leaf

CROSSWORT
Cruciata laevipes
F: Rubiaceae

With stem leaves in cross-like whorls and clustered, honey-scented flowers, this perennial grows in grassy places across Europe and Asia.



60 cm
23 1/2 in



QUININE TREE
Cinchona calisaya
F: Rubiaceae

The anti-malaria drug quinine comes from the bark of this S. American tree. Seeds were smuggled to Asia in the mid 19th century for cultivation there.



CAPE JASMINE
Gardenia jasminoides
F: Rubiaceae

Originating in Asia, this evergreen shrub has fragrant, waxy, tubular white flowers that turn yellow with age. These ripen to berry-like fruits.

COFFEE SHRUB
Coffea arabica
F: Rubiaceae

Native to Ethiopia but transported elsewhere for cultivation, this evergreen shrub produces crimson drupes (stoned fruits) within which are two seeds (coffee beans).



10 m / 33 ft

fruits red when ripe